

LOCAL SPORTS

And slow it goes: Lakewood wins

Tim Gebhardt
The Chronicle-Telegram

GRAFTON — You've heard all the clichés around tournament time.

Cinderella. New Season. March Madness. Throw out the records, everybody's 0-0.

Meet Lakewood, a living cliché if ever there was one.

All the Rangers did Wednesday was win their third Division I tournament game after entering postseason with just five wins all season.

Lakewood eliminated favored North Olmsted, 35-31, pretty much the same way they derailed top-seeded and state-ranked Medina, 44-41, last Friday.

Coach Bob Patton orchestrated the perfect plan by shortening the game to give his team a chance to win. The Rangers — well-seasoned after the Lake Erie League grind against of teams like Shaker, Cleveland Heights and Euclid — were patient, took away North Olmsted's strengths and played smart basketball.

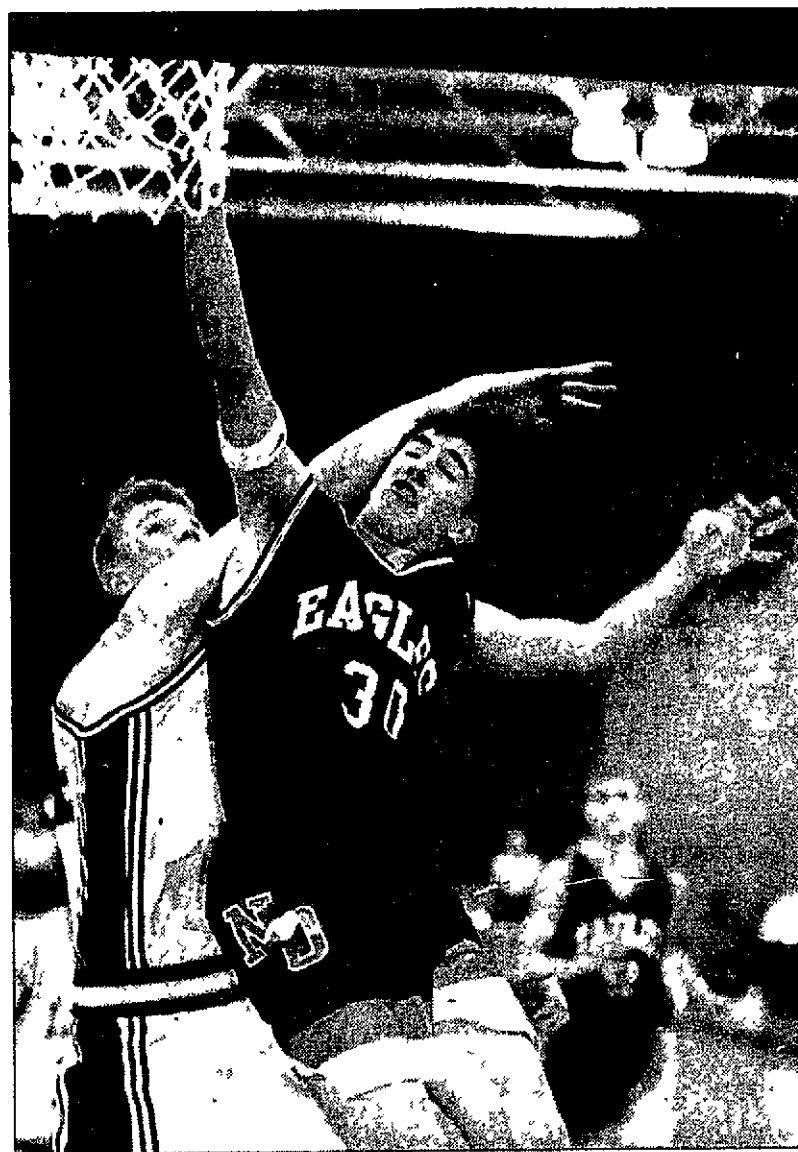
"We're just doing what we have to do to win basketball games," Patton said. "We took away their whole middle action. They do a great job of running their motion, back-cutting and opening the floor."

"Some teams call it (defense) a triangle-and-two but it was more taking away their middle action. They never got any drives to the bucket off their offense."

"We did a great job shutting down the all-conference kid, No. 22 (Aaron Kerr). I thought he was the big key to their whole offense. He penetrates, he dishes, he scores. We had to take him out of the game."

Kerr had just four points and didn't score at all until the final quarter when he rebounded his own miss for a basket and hit a short jumper from the left baseline to bring the Eagles to within 26-25 at the five-minute mark.

"They (Lakewood) did a great job taking away our shooters," said Eagles coach Tim Schmotzer. "We didn't rebound



LINDA MURPHY / CHRONICLE

HEAD GAMES: Lakewood's Matt Fannin swats North Olmsted's Justin Christafaris under the basket Wednesday night.

the basketball. We didn't penetrate. We didn't get the ball reversed like we usually do. We just didn't attack."

Lakewood outrebounded the Eagles 28-18 and stayed alive despite missing three of five free throws down the stretch. The Rangers still managed to increase their lead to 35-31 as the clock ran out on North Olmsted and its own glorious run.

The Eagles — down by the final four-point spread — fur-

iously tried to salvage a win, but missed all three of its last-ditch shots.

In fact, North Olmsted missed its last five after junior sharpshooter Justin Christafaris hit a three to give the Eagles their last lead, 31-30, with 2½ minutes to go.

North Olmsted, making its first district appearance since 1953, finished 15-8 — its best season since going 15-4 in 1971-72. The best the Eagles ever finished

is 17-3 in 1966-67.

"We're disappointed right now," Schmotzer said. "It doesn't diminish the season we've had. The kids have been super all season — every practice, every game. Once it settles in, they'll realize what they've accomplished. We have five of our top six players returning so we can build off this."

With the win, the Rangers advance to meet tonight's Midview-Brunswick winner with a trip to the Toledo Regional on the line.

Host Midview — Lorain County's last Division I hope — is the lone seed still alive in its own field.

Christafaris was the only player to reach double figures for either team with 16 points. The Eagles were held to 12 field goals in 31 attempts and five free throws in six.

Lakewood			N.Olmsted		
Brittan	2	3	Christafaris	5	2
Roundtree	3	0	Kerr	2	0
Patterson	1	2	S. Trapp	2	0
Crawford	1	1	Steele	1	1
Fannin	1	0	Thompson	1	0
Bechford	0	2	Hazzard	1	0
Eachus	1	0	Rick	1	0
Fisher	0	0			
Totals	11	35	Totals	12	31

Points by Quarters: 1 2 3 4 T
Lakewood 8 7 11 9 — 35
No Olmsted 7 8 11 11 — 35

Three-point goals: Lakewood Crawford, Patterson North Olmsted Christafaris 2

BRIEFS

Elyria Catholic tickets on sale

ELYRIA — Tickets for Friday's Elyria Catholic-Lutheran West Division III boys district championship basketball game set for 7:30 p.m. at Elyria High are on sale at EC's athletic office today and Friday between 8:30 a.m. and 3:30 p.m.

A rebate from school-sold tickets is returned by the state association to the schools. All ticket proceeds bought at the Elyria High gym door go completely to the OHSAA.

Adult tickets are \$5, students \$3.

FALLS

From C1

The winner of Saturday night's game earns a berth in the Bowling Green regional next week.

"I thought in the first half, we handled their press fairly well," said Avon Lake coach Dave Olinger, whose Shoremen finish the season 12-11. "But the third quarter has been bad for us all year and it hurt us again tonight."

"They (Bulldogs) go in at the half and make some adjustments and the third quarter is good for them."

Falls coach Pat Donohue did exactly that.

"At the half, we discussed the way we play basketball," he said. "We made a couple of changes on

ALake			OFalls		
Inglright	3	8	Mucha	3	10
Kalinik	4	2	Josak	2	1
Gunnth	2	0	Koch	2	1
Hamilton	2	0	MWills	1	6
James	2	1	Garsney	10	20
May	2	1	BYills	2	3
Welch	3	4	Flores	2	2
Hamel	1	0	Radigan	8	3
Sidinger	3	0	Holland	0	0
			Mazella	0	0
			Schndr	0	1
Totals	17	32	Totals	31	75

Points by Quarters: 1 2 3 4 T
ALake 16 11 14 — 52
OFalls 20 11 25 19 — 75

Three-point goals: Olmsted Falls — Mucha 2

defense, changed our press and the way we trap. We tried to lull them to sleep a little bit and Sean (Radigan) did a good job of reading who was going to get the ball on the inbounds pass."

"But Dave (Olinger) had his team well prepared for us. They came out very intensely and they wanted to win more than we did

in the first half."

Olinger started a smaller lineup the first half, the idea being it would be quicker and more effective against Falls' full-court press.

They did a good job of beating the press and Brian Inglright, a 5-foot-11 sophomore, was frequently in the lane, driving for the basket and drawing fouls. Two of his first-half field goals were drives in the lane, and he made six straight foul shots, four the first quarter.

But Falls' new-look defense held Inglright to two foul shots in the second half. Still, his 14 points led Avon Lake in scoring. Joe Kostelnik, a 6-0 senior, added 10.

CLEARVIEW

From C1

Clearview's Layla Willis got a rebound basket in the opening seconds of the fourth quarter. From there, Delphos went on an 8-0 tear. A three from Nicole Simmons at 3:35 temporarily stopped the bleeding for the Clippers.

Little did the Clippers know that Simmons' bomb would be their last points of the season. The Wildcats closed the game with an 11-0 run

Clearview			Delphos		
Simmons	1	0	Willis	5	14
Tolway	3	0	Kill	5	0
Willis	6	0	Penner	1	1
Finnegan	2	0	Marso	1	5
Davis	2	0	Kraoote	2	3
			Moore	2	7
			Casemier	1	0
			Fruchey	0	2
			Ricker	6	1
			Ebbesott	3	0
			Winnichr	0	0
			Jefferson	2	7
Totals	15	0	Totals	28	72

Points by Quarters: 1 2 3 4 T
Clearview 1 13 11 5 — 33
Delphos 17 9 17 19 — 62

Three-point goals: Clearview — Simmons, Tolway, Willis, Delphos Jefferson — Wreede 3

Also, we don't do a whole lot of scouting. We more or less play our own style of game and see what happens."

Horvath said he figured mistakes would be the difference and they were.

"I said before the game that

the team that makes fewer mistakes would be the winner," he said. "Delphos is very sound fundamentally. They pay attention to details."

"It comes down to doing the little things. When you don't and your opponent does, you find yourself digging out of a big hole early. That's what happened to us tonight."

"And we didn't play very good defense. That's really disappointing because we've worked hard to do that all season long."

Wreede had 14 points, Ricker 13 and Kandl Kill 10 to lead the Wildcats.

Willis closed out her Clipper career with 13 points, the only Clearview player to reach double figures.

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